she did a bunch of run-of-the-mill projects which didn't exactly stretch her thespian skills. That changed with *Uri* and *Bala*. Since then, Yami has found herself shuttling between intense dramas (*A Thursday*, *Chor Nikal Ke Bhaga*), some with a strong political bent (*Uri*, *Article 370*, *Haq*), and comic outings (*Bala*, *Dhoom Dhaam*). "I am a fan of versatility. I don't have any set genre," says Yami, while denying that she now gravitates towards politically-charged narratives. "I go by what I enjoy and connect with. I don't overthink it." Her upcoming line-up of work which includes five films, she adds, is different.

That she is spoiled for choice after becoming a mother last year is proof of how the industry has progressed in terms of the range of opportunities that it gives to actresses post motherhood. "Given the phase I am in professionally regardless of my personal and family life, it's a great statement about the industry and the audience who appreciate you for who you are and what talent you hold."

The question now is, will that talent be recognised with *Haq*? Could it bring alive the scenario she has dreamt of—standing in the middle of the stage to deliver a winning speech in front of an audience of peers? Yami, though, is measuring *Haq*'s success in another way. "The kind of scripts and roles I am being offered [after it], I'd say, yes, the film is a game changer," she says. "I have stopped chasing the moment and like to go with the flow." If her work in *Haq* is anything to go by, the approach is clearly working. ■

—Suhani Singh

CINEMA ▼

A BOLD **NEW VOICE**

Filmmaker Tribeny Rai's *Shape of Momo* is a deeply personal debut that turns the lens inward



When Sikkimese filmmaker Tribeny Rai shared the first cut of her feature directorial debut *Shape of Momo* with her friends, they were surprised that she had made a film about herself. Only, Tribeny wouldn't call the film autobiographical but one that's "deeply personal", with characters drawn from her experiences. After all, as legendary filmmaker Martin Scorsese famously said, "The personal is universal."

Tribeny's leading lady Bishnu (pitch-perfect Nepali actress Gaumaya Gurung) is not the easiest heroine to root for. Having returned to her ancestral village in Sikkim from Delhi, she doesn't make the best impression on her mother and sister who find her tendency to challenge the status quo and demeanour with locals off-putting. "I have been told Bishnu is too strong-headed," says Tribeny. "You sometimes can't sympathise and empathise with her." Yet, Tribeny believes that by sticking to the principle of 'honesty is the best policy', she has created a shero whom audiences, especially independent women, will relate to. "When people say this story is about women, I feel society puts you in the bracket of righteousness...she can't do anything wrong and only then be a heroine," she adds.



SLICE OF LIFE *Bishnu, played by Nepali actress Gaumaya Gurung, is not the easiest heroine to root for*

For Tribeny, a graduate of the Satyajit Ray Institute of Filmmaking in Kolkata, it was imperative that her first feature be set in her home state and reflect on life there. "Because we look different, I never saw a character like me or one I could resonate with in Bollywood films when I was growing up," she says. "People from the [northeast] region are always at the periphery...we are never the heroes of our own story. There was this strong need to tell our stories from our place."

And she has succeeded in telling a poignant one. *Shape of Momo* is already making waves on the film festival circuit, having won accolades in Busan and Kolkata. Even as she tours with the film and hopes for a release, especially in north Bengal, Sikkim, Shillong and Dehradun, where the Nepali-speaking population is concentrated, Tribeny wants more people from the rest of India to see the film. "As a filmmaker," she says, "you have to show a mirror to society. I want people to reflect on how women are treated." ■

—Suhani Singh